FIGHTERS OF THE SPANISH CIVIL WAR

The failure of an attempted military coup in Spain in July 1936 led to a three-year civil war, in which right-wing Nationalists led by General Francisco Franco fought forces loyal to the Republican government. Nazi Germany and Fascist Italy intervened on the Nationalist side, while the Republicans received support on a smaller scale from Soviet Russia and from volunteer International Brigades. Apart from advanced experiments in the use of air power by the German Condor Legion, the war was mostly fought using World War I-era tactics and equipment. The Nationalists were ultimately victorious in a conflict that cost more than 500,000 lives, around a quarter of them civilians or prisoners massacred in cold blood.

NATIONALISTS

The core of the Nationalist forces was the Army of Africa, which occupied Spain's North African colony, Spanish Morocco. The elite of this force was the Spanish Foreign Legion, created in 1920 on the model of the French Foreign Legion, but recruited almost entirely from Spanish volunteers – at least until the civil war brought a rush of recruits from Portugal and elsewhere. The Army of Africa also included large numbers of tough Moroccan Riff tribesmen serving under Spanish officers. Unlike the troops on the mainland, who were mostly ill-trained conscripts, the Legion and Moroccan soldiers were hardened professionals.

After the Army of Africa, the most effective troops on the Nationalist side were the Catholic royalist militias known as the "requetés". Chiefly hill farmers from the Navarre region, these soldiers fought in a crusading spirit, "one hand holding a grenade, the other a rosary". The Nationalists also had the support of the militia of the fascist Falangist movement and of much of the Civil Guard, a paramilitary police force that was much better equipped than the conscript army.

> "SPANIARDS! THE NATION CALLS TO HER DEFENCE ALL THOSE WHO HEAR THE HOLY NAME OF SPAIN."
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> **FRANCISCO FRANCO**, MANIFESTO OF JULY 19, 1936

At first the rapid progress made by the Army of Africa promised an easy Nationalist triumph. Ferried across to southern Spain aboard German and Italian aircraft, they advanced on Madrid massacring thousands along the way. But stiffening resistance brought the colonial troops to a halt in the suburbs of the capital, condemning the Nationalists to fighting a long war of attrition. The superior foreign support they enjoyed, and the disunity of their opponents, eventually gave Franco's men a hard-fought victory.



SPANISH MAUSER MODEL 1893



The siege of Madrid
Nationalist soldiers attack an enemy position on the Madrid front. After three years of fighting, the city finally fell to Franco's forces in March 1939.